SORT 1 / 78

ENTRYWAY

Landing Zone

Empty the tray and the paper stack onto the floor. Keys that open nothing, loyalty cards, dead batteries and last month's flyers leave now. Every piece of mail gets a verdict of act, file, or recycle before anything goes back on the surface.

STRAIGHTEN 2 / 78

ENTRYWAY

Landing Zone

Put the tray where your hand actually opens on the way in, not where the furniture happens to be. Keys and sunglasses in the tray, one upright folder for act-on paper, and the charger plugged in at the far end away from anything that drips.

SHINE 3 / 78

ENTRYWAY

Landing Zone

Lift the tray out and wipe under it, then wipe the tray itself. Keys shed grit and coins leave a gray film that tells you exactly how long it has been since anyone did this.

SAFETY 4 / 78

ENTRYWAY

Landing Zone

The charging cable and the umbrella drip line must not share a spot. Check what else is on the outlet feeding the dock, because a lamp, a seasonal heater and a four-port charger on one strip is this room's usual overload.

STANDARDIZE 5 / 78

ENTRYWAY

Landing Zone

Photograph the cleared tray with the folder standing beside it, print it small, and tape it inside the coat cupboard door at the height people glance while hanging a coat. The tray then teaches itself.

SUSTAIN 6 / 78

ENTRYWAY

Landing Zone

The folder rides to the sofa with you after dinner, one sheet at a time, and each adult works their own. Slip shows from the doorway: a second pile beside the tray, or a folder too fat to stand up. Recovery is one five minute sitting with the recycling bin at your feet, not a re-sort of the surface. This zone drifts faster than ...

SORT 7 / 78

ENTRYWAY

Coat and Outerwear Zone

Take every coat down. Anything that did not go outdoors once through the last cold season leaves, and so do the single gloves you kept in case the other one turned up. Off-season coats go to a bedroom closet, not to the far end of the same rail.

STRAIGHTEN 8 / 78

ENTRYWAY

Coat and Outerwear Zone

Hooks for what goes on and off daily, hangers only for the wool coat that creases. Set the lowest hook at the height of the shortest person who uses it, and keep the two hooks nearest the door empty for visitors.

SHINE 9 / 78

ENTRYWAY

Coat and Outerwear Zone

Brush the shoulders of the hanging coats, wipe the shelf where dust settles on top of the hat bin, and tip out the umbrella stand. There is always water and grit in the bottom of it.

SAFETY 10 / 78

ENTRYWAY

Coat and Outerwear Zone

Hang your full weight on each hook before you trust it with a soaked winter coat. Hooks driven into plasterboard without an anchor pull out later, with the coat still attached and a lump of wall behind it.

STANDARDIZE 11 / 78

ENTRYWAY

Coat and Outerwear Zone

Write the contents and the season on the shelf bin, hats and gloves, winter, so whoever reaches up for it in October knows without opening the lid whether they have the right bin.

SUSTAIN 12 / 78

ENTRYWAY

Coat and Outerwear Zone

Whoever loads the washing machine walks the rail on the way past, under a minute, returning whatever was left on a chair back or the bannister. The count does the telling: two hooks stay empty, so a full rail read from the doorway means the room is already over. Recovery is carrying the two coats nobody wore this month up to a ...

SORT 13 / 78

ENTRYWAY

Shoe and Boot Zone

Pull every shoe out and pair them up on the floor. Odd shoes, outgrown children's pairs and the sneakers with the split sole all go, and so does the tin of polish that has dried solid.

STRAIGHTEN 14 / 78

ENTRYWAY

Shoe and Boot Zone

Daily pairs on the rack at a height you can reach standing up, boots in the tray because they will always come in wet, off-season pairs boxed in a closet. Nothing at all on the floor between the door and the rack.

SHINE 15 / 78

ENTRYWAY

Shoe and Boot Zone

Take the boot tray outside and hose it. The salt and grit sitting in it is precisely what scratches your hallway floor. Wipe down the rack shelves too, they hold more dried mud than they look like they do.

SAFETY 16 / 78

ENTRYWAY

Shoe and Boot Zone

Wet soles on a hard floor are how people go down in this room. The tray has to catch the drip, and anything that walked in soaked stays on the tray until it is dry rather than being carried through the house.

STANDARDIZE 17 / 78

ENTRYWAY

Shoe and Boot Zone

Give each person their own named shelf on the rack, the name written at the shelf edge, so a third pair has visibly nowhere to stand and nobody has to count.

SUSTAIN 18 / 78

ENTRYWAY

Shoe and Boot Zone

Shoes come off inside the door and go onto the rack before the coat, while both hands are still free, each person to their own named shelf. A two second act on arrival, or a ten minute job on Saturday. The floor is the signal: one pair standing off the rack means a shelf is full. Recovery is one person's overflow going to a ...

SORT 19 / 78

ENTRYWAY

Entry Console or Bench

Tip the drawer out onto the bench. Dead batteries, pens that do not write, single earbuds, sunscreen from three summers ago and takeout menus all go now. Anything you would not want while wearing your outdoor shoes belongs in a different room.

STRAIGHTEN 20 / 78

ENTRYWAY

Entry Console or Bench

Divide the drawer into named sections and hold to them: dog leash and waste bags, sunscreen and insect spray, a flashlight, one pen. Bags and the vacuum go underneath the bench, never on the seat.

SHINE 21 / 78

ENTRYWAY

Entry Console or Bench

Take the drawer fully out and tip the sand and crumbs out of its corners. Wipe the seat itself, which collects the same grit as the floor because people sit on it in outdoor clothes.

SAFETY 22 / 78

ENTRYWAY

Entry Console or Bench

Fix the console to the wall if it is taller than it is deep, because children climb open drawer fronts like a ladder. Move the box cutter and the scissors out of the shallow drawer that opens at toddler head height.

STANDARDIZE 23 / 78

ENTRYWAY

Entry Console or Bench

Write the three permitted top items on a card and tape it inside the drawer, so the cap survives everyone who did not read this book.

SUSTAIN 24 / 78

ENTRYWAY

Entry Console or Bench

Whoever clears the dinner table carries the plates past the bench and takes the top back to three on the way through, which adds nothing to a trip already being made. The seat is the signal, not the top: if you cannot sit down to lace a boot without lifting something, the bench has stopped being a bench. Recovery is one armful ...

SORT 25 / 78

ENTRYWAY

Door, Mat, and Immediate Floor

Nothing is stored on this patch of floor, so the recycling bag, the parcel waiting to go back and the sports kit all move tonight. Give outgoing returns one named spot in another room and carry the rest to where they actually belong.

STRAIGHTEN 26 / 78

ENTRYWAY

Door, Mat, and Immediate Floor

Two mats and only two. Coarse outside to scrape, absorbent inside to dry. The inside mat needs to be long enough that both feet land on it while walking, and most are not, which is exactly how the grit gets past.

SHINE 27 / 78

ENTRYWAY

Door, Mat, and Immediate Floor

Vacuum the inside mat on both faces, then take it outdoors, beat it and wash it. Run a cloth along the bottom edge of the door and along the threshold strip, because that dark line is all the grit the mat never caught.

SAFETY 28 / 78

ENTRYWAY

Door, Mat, and Immediate Floor

A curled mat corner and a mat that slides on hard floor are the two ways this threshold puts somebody down. Grip or tape the edges flat, and dry the floor immediately when someone comes in soaked rather than leaving it to evaporate.

STANDARDIZE 29 / 78

ENTRYWAY

Door, Mat, and Immediate Floor

Run a thin line of tape around where the mat should sit, so a mat kicked out of position is obvious to anyone walking in rather than only to you.

SUSTAIN 30 / 78

ENTRYWAY

Door, Mat, and Immediate Floor

The mat sits on the route back to the vacuum cupboard, so whoever ran the vacuum straightens and cleans it last, every time. Overnight the job is smaller: the last person in nudges it back inside its taped outline with a foot. Slip is visible before you reach the door, as a curled corner outside the tape or a gray line of grit ...

SORT 31 / 78

KITCHEN

Primary Prep Counter

Take everything off the counter and set it on the dining table, then let only three things back: what you cut on, what you cut with, and what you season with. The vitamins, the second cutting board, the bread bag and the pile of receipts find homes elsewhere or leave.

STRAIGHTEN 32 / 78

KITCHEN

Primary Prep Counter

Put the board where you already stand without thinking, then build outward from it. Knives on a wall strip or in a block on your dominant side, oil and salt behind the board rather than beside it, mixing bowls in the cabinet directly underneath so you can reach one without turning around.

SHINE 33 / 78

KITCHEN

Primary Prep Counter

Lift the toaster and the kettle instead of wiping around them, because crumbs collect under the appliance feet and never move. Run a damp cloth along the seam where the counter meets the backsplash, and shake the toaster crumb tray out over the bin.

SAFETY 34 / 78

KITCHEN

Primary Prep Counter

Knives belong in a block, on a magnetic strip, or in a bladed sleeve in a drawer, never loose among the utensils and never blade-up in the drying rack. Keep the kettle and toaster cords off the sink side of the counter, where a wet hand meets them.

STANDARDIZE 35 / 78

KITCHEN

Primary Prep Counter

Mark the clear run so it is not a matter of opinion. A short strip of tape under the counter lip, or the outline of the board itself, tells everyone in the house where the work surface starts and that it stays empty.

SUSTAIN 36 / 78

KITCHEN

Primary Prep Counter

Whoever presses start on the dishwasher puts the board back down onto bare counter, about a minute, and that settles the whole run. The board is the gauge: if it will not sit flat, or you have to move something to lay it down, the clear run has gone. Recovery is sweeping the strays into a basket and carrying the basket out of ...

SORT 37 / 78

KITCHEN

Sink and Dishwashing Zone

Pull everything out from under the sink and line it up on the floor. Combine the three half-empty bottles of the same spray, bin what has separated or lost its label, and move out anything that is not dish, sink, or plumbing related, because that cabinet gets damp and is the wrong home for spare bulbs, paper goods, or vases.

STRAIGHTEN 38 / 78

KITCHEN

Sink and Dishwashing Zone

Soap and brush live in a caddy you can lift with one wet hand, so wiping under them takes no planning. Dishwasher tablets go in a container beside the machine rather than across the room, and the towel gets a bar within reach of somebody already standing at the basin.

SHINE 39 / 78

KITCHEN

Sink and Dishwashing Zone

The sponge is the dirtiest object in the room: wring it out and stand it on edge after every wash, and retire it the day it smells while dry. Scrub the drain flange, wipe the rubber seal all the way around the dishwasher door, and pull the dishwasher filter out and rinse it, because a filter that has never come out since the ...

SAFETY 40 / 78

KITCHEN

Sink and Dishwashing Zone

Never store bleach beside an ammonia or toilet cleaner under this sink, and never combine them in the basin; keep them apart, capped, and labels facing out. If small children live here or visit, this is the one kitchen cabinet that genuinely earns a latch.

STANDARDIZE 41 / 78

KITCHEN

Sink and Dishwashing Zone

Write the empty-sink standard on a card taped inside the cabinet door: dishes in the machine or washed, basin wiped, brush standing, towel hung. A standard is the best way you know today, written down.

SUSTAIN 42 / 78

KITCHEN

Sink and Dishwashing Zone

Whoever switches the kitchen light off empties the basin and wipes it dry, two minutes, and that person is different every night, which is why the rule hangs on the switch rather than on a name. The morning tells you: one bowl left overnight is a full sink by tomorrow night, because a basin with something in it reads as ...

SORT 43 / 78

KITCHEN

Upper Cabinet Zone

Count the mugs, then count the people who drink from them. The conference giveaway, the chipped one, and the one nobody ever chooses off the shelf come out first, because chips and crazed glaze are the easy calls and they shorten the argument about the rest.

STRAIGHTEN 44 / 78

KITCHEN

Upper Cabinet Zone

Put dinner plates and everyday bowls at eye level on the side nearest the dishwasher or the table, glasses beside them, and send the serving platters and the punch bowl to the top shelf, where a step stool is an honest once-a-year cost.

SHINE 45 / 78

KITCHEN

Upper Cabinet Zone

Take each shelf completely empty before wiping, because the band of dust at the back is how you find out it has not been cleared in years. Wipe the underside of the cabinet nearest the stovetop, where a greasy film settles that you only see when you look at it from an angle.

SAFETY

46 / 78

KITCHEN

Upper Cabinet Zone

Heavy and breakable do not belong above head height. The stack of casserole dishes or the cast iron lid stored overhead is the one that eventually comes down on somebody, so move that weight low. Use a real step stool, never a chair edge and never an open drawer front.

STANDARDIZE

47 / 78

KITCHEN

Upper Cabinet Zone

Label the shelf edge rather than the contents: plates, bowls, glasses, mugs. Then anyone emptying the dishwasher can put things away correctly without asking you where they go.

SUSTAIN

48 / 78

KITCHEN

Upper Cabinet Zone

Emptying the dishwasher is the check, done by whoever is emptying it, so the household audits this zone several times a week without an extra minute. The signal comes to your hand: a clean mug you cannot lift without moving another, or a plate with nowhere obvious to go. Either means the shelf is over its limit, and recovery is ...

SORT

49 / 78

KITCHEN

Lower Cabinet and Cookware Zone

Empty the entire cabinet onto the floor, which is the only way you will ever find the third saucepan and the wok bought for one weekend. Keep what actually cooked something in the past year. Nonstick worn through to the metal in the middle is not a spare, it is finished, and it goes to metal recycling rather than to the back of ...

STRAIGHTEN

50 / 78

KITCHEN

Lower Cabinet and Cookware Zone

Nest by size but cap any stack at three, with a cloth or a sheet of paper between coated surfaces. Lids stand in a rack or on a rail inside the door, and baking sheets go on edge in a divider so you stop lifting three to reach the fourth.

SHINE

51 / 78

KITCHEN

Lower Cabinet and Cookware Zone

Wipe the shelf floor itself, where oil creeps down from pan bases and holds dust into a tacky film that resists a dry cloth. While everything is out, twist every pan handle and tighten any rivet or screw that moves.

SAFETY

52 / 78

KITCHEN

Lower Cabinet and Cookware Zone

Keep the cast iron and the full stockpot on the cabinet floor, never above waist height, and lift them from a squat rather than bending over the open door. If a stack slides when the door is closed hard, it will one day land on a foot, so build the stack so it survives a slam.

STANDARDIZE

53 / 78

KITCHEN

Lower Cabinet and Cookware Zone

Size the divider slots to your actual pans and write the pan on the front edge of each slot, so the wide skillet slot cannot quietly become the place lids get dropped.

SUSTAIN

54 / 78

KITCHEN

Lower Cabinet and Cookware Zone

When the pans come off the drying rack they go back into their named slots, done by whoever set them there to dry. The stovetop is the tell. A pan that sleeps on the burner is not laziness, it is a slot that costs a crouch to reach, and the pan is reporting that honestly. Recovery is changing the slot rather than the person ...

SORT 55 / 78

PRIMARY BEDROOM

Bed and Bedding Zone

Strip the bed and pull out everything underneath it. Sheets worn thin at the hip, blankets gone pilled and scratchy, and pillows that stay folded in half when you bend them are finished; they leave as rags or textile recycling, not as spares for a guest who never comes.

STRAIGHTEN 56 / 78

PRIMARY BEDROOM

Bed and Bedding Zone

Store each sheet set folded inside one of its own pillowcases so the flat sheet and the fitted sheet stop traveling separately, and keep this bed's linen on one shelf instead of stacked in with guest doubles and kid singles.

SHINE 57 / 78

PRIMARY BEDROOM

Bed and Bedding Zone

With the mattress bare, vacuum the whole surface and the seam where the protector tucks under, then run the vacuum head down behind the headboard where dust and hair pack against the wall.

SAFETY 58 / 78

PRIMARY BEDROOM

Bed and Bedding Zone

Nothing goes under the bed that sticks out into the strip of floor you cross in the dark, and nothing heavy sits on a headboard shelf directly above where your head rests.

STANDARDIZE 59 / 78

PRIMARY BEDROOM

Bed and Bedding Zone

Write down what a made bed means in this house, down to how many pillows go on and whether the duvet is folded back or pulled flat, so it looks the same on the mornings you do it and the mornings someone else does. A standard is the best way you know today, written down.

SUSTAIN 60 / 78

PRIMARY BEDROOM

Bed and Bedding Zone

Make the bed before you leave the room, while the duvet is still thrown back and it takes one pull. In a two person bed it belongs to whoever gets up second, worth agreeing out loud once rather than negotiating every morning. The cover is the signal: a made bed holds the agreed pillows and nothing else, so folded laundry on it ...

SORT 61 / 78

PRIMARY BEDROOM

Primary Closet

Pull out anything you have not worn in a year, anything waiting on a repair you are never going to make, and every wire hanger and plastic sheath the dry cleaner sent home. Winter coats and heavy knits go into a labeled bin or the guest wardrobe so the rod carries only what this month asks for.

STRAIGHTEN 62 / 78

PRIMARY BEDROOM

Primary Closet

Switch to one hanger style so everything hangs at the same depth and the row reads flat, group by type and then by shade, and hang the short items together so the floor under them opens up for the shoe rack. Bags stand up on the shelf rather than nesting inside one another where you forget the inner three.

SHINE 63 / 78

PRIMARY BEDROOM

Primary Closet

Clear the floor completely, vacuum it and the corners, wipe the shelf edges and the rod itself where hangers leave a gray line, and check the back wall and baseboard for damp before the shoes go back down.

SAFETY 64 / 78

PRIMARY BEDROOM

Primary Closet

An overloaded rod pulls its brackets out of the plasterboard, and it does it while you are standing underneath reaching in. Lean your weight on it and see, anchor the brackets into a stud, and get the shoe pile off the floor so you are not standing on a heel in the dark.

STANDARDIZE 65 / 78

PRIMARY BEDROOM

Primary Closet

The rod is full when you cannot slide two fingers between hangers. From there it is one in, one out, and the bare stretch of rod at the end stays bare, because that is where the next coat lands.

SUSTAIN 66 / 78

PRIMARY BEDROOM

Primary Closet

Turn every hanger backwards at the start of a season and turn each one the right way round as you wear the item, so the record keeps itself. Slip gets measured with two fingers: when they will not fit between hangers the rod is full, and from there it is one in, one out. Recovery is not a purge, it is reading the hangers still ...

SORT 67 / 78

PRIMARY BATHROOM

Vanity Counter

Pull everything off the counter onto a towel and put back only what your hands touched today and yesterday. The travel bottles, the sample sachets, and the hair tie graveyard go into a drawer or out of the room entirely.

STRAIGHTEN 68 / 78

PRIMARY BATHROOM

Vanity Counter

Give the daily set one tray, on the side you reach with your dominant hand. The heat tool gets a heat-safe rest and its cord parks behind the basin rather than draped across it.

SHINE 69 / 78

PRIMARY BATHROOM

Vanity Counter

Wipe the tray, then the counter under it, then the base of the faucet where toothpaste dries into a crust. Finish with the mirror and the light switch plate, the thing in this room nobody ever wipes.

SAFETY 70 / 78

PRIMARY BATHROOM

Vanity Counter

Water and a plugged-in dryer share one small surface in here. Keep the cord on the far side of the basin from the faucet, and pull the plug at the wall the moment you set the tool down, not once your hair is finished.

STANDARDIZE 71 / 78

PRIMARY BATHROOM

Vanity Counter

Write the four-product limit on a strip of tape stuck under the tray, and tape a photo of the cleared counter inside the vanity door. A fifth bottle then has something to argue with before it lands.

SUSTAIN 72 / 78

PRIMARY BATHROOM

Vanity Counter

The tray goes back to match the photo when you rinse your toothbrush at night, same moment every night, each adult resetting their own products. Twenty seconds. Slip is a fifth bottle standing on bare stone, seen from the door before anything else, because this counter's whole standard is the emptiness either side of the basin ...

SORT 73 / 78

PRIMARY BATHROOM

Under-Sink Cabinet

Take it all out and line it up on the floor by job: glass, tub and tile, toilet, drain, polish. You will find three half-full bottles of the same thing and one you cannot identify, and the one you cannot identify goes.

STRAIGHTEN 74 / 78

PRIMARY BATHROOM

Under-Sink Cabinet

Build the bins around the P-trap instead of fighting it, keeping the joint and the valves visible. Paper goods and bulk toiletries take the side with headroom, and sprays sit at the front where you can read a label without kneeling.

SHINE 75 / 78

PRIMARY BATHROOM

Under-Sink Cabinet

Wipe the cabinet floor and look hard for a dark ring or a soft patch in the board, which is what a slow leak looks like before it looks like water. Wipe the neck of every bottle before it goes back so the pale tray never turns sticky.

SAFETY 76 / 78

PRIMARY BATHROOM

Under-Sink Cabinet

Never store bleach where it can tip into an ammonia-based cleaner, and never decant anything into a drink bottle. This cabinet sits at toddler height, so if small children come through the house, fit a magnetic catch or move the chemistry above the sink line.

STANDARDIZE 77 / 78

PRIMARY BATHROOM

Under-Sink Cabinet

One open container per job, backstock capped at two. Label the front edge of each bin with the job rather than the brand, so the bowl cleaner cannot quietly end up among the glass sprays.

SUSTAIN 78 / 78

PRIMARY BATHROOM

Under-Sink Cabinet

Every hand soap refill is a leak check: crouch, run your eyes over the cabinet floor and the trap joint, then close the doors. Ten seconds, by whoever refilled the soap. Slip is anything stacked on the pale tray or standing where it hides the trap, because the tray only works if it can show you a drip you were not expecting ...

The standards that keep these zones

ENTRYWAY · LANDING ZONE

The surface holds the tray and the folder and nothing else, and keys never ride out of the house in a coat pocket that lives on a hanger.

> As you take your coat off, your hands are already full and already stopped. That is the moment everything in them goes into the tray.

ENTRYWAY · COAT AND OUTERWEAR ZONE

Two empty hooks at all times. If there is no empty hook, one coat is in the wrong room.

> On the first morning cold enough that you go looking for gloves, that is the seasonal swap. Do it that morning, standing there, rather than noting it for later.

ENTRYWAY · SHOE AND BOOT ZONE

Two pairs per person at the door, soles down, everything else lives somewhere that is not the entryway.

> On the night the bins go out, the boot tray goes out with them and comes back empty.

ENTRYWAY · ENTRY CONSOLE OR BENCH

Three items on the top, an empty seat, and every drawer section holding one named category.

> You already open this drawer to put the dog leash back after a walk. While it is open, glance at the top and take it back to three.

ENTRYWAY · DOOR, MAT, AND IMMEDIATE FLOOR

Nothing is stored on the floor inside the door's swing, ever, and both mats lie flat inside their taped outline.

> Whoever comes home last and locks the door straightens the mat with a foot before turning the key.

KITCHEN · PRIMARY PREP COUNTER

The clear run stays clear: one board, one knife block or strip, one seasoning within reach, and nothing parked on the work surface overnight.

> When you press start on the dishwasher, the counter clears.

KITCHEN · SINK AND DISHWASHING ZONE

Empty sink, dry basin, one brush and one sponge standing, cleaners on one tray with the plumbing visible.

> When the coffee brews in the morning, the sink gets checked and cleared.

KITCHEN · UPPER CABINET ZONE

Daily dishes between shoulder and eye height, one category per stack, top shelf reserved for what you use less than monthly.

> Every time the clean dishwasher gets emptied.

KITCHEN · LOWER CABINET AND COOKWARE ZONE

Stacks capped at three, lids racked, heaviest pieces on the cabinet floor, and the two nightly pans at the front.

> When the pans come off the drying rack.

PRIMARY BEDROOM · BED AND BEDDING ZONE

Two sheet sets for this bed, each folded inside its own pillowcase; a made bed means the agreed pillow count and nothing else on the cover.

> When you strip the bed to wash the sheets, look underneath it before the clean set goes on.

PRIMARY BEDROOM · PRIMARY CLOSET

One hanger style, grouped by type then shade, two fingers of space between items, and one in one out once the rod is full.

> When you hang up the first coat of a new season, turn every hanger on the rod backwards and start the count again.

PRIMARY BATHROOM · VANITY COUNTER

The counter carries one liftable tray and nothing beside it. Anything used less than daily lives behind a door.

> The nightly toothbrush rinse. The tray goes back to the photo before you leave the room.

PRIMARY BATHROOM · UNDER-SINK CABINET

The P-trap and both shut-off valves stay in plain sight, one open bottle per job, backstock capped at two.

> Every hand soap refill. Crouch, check the cabinet floor, then close the doors.